

HISTORY HACK · DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

Read the following three primary source excerpts and answer the prompt below.

US.38 — Describe the Scopes Trial of 1925, including the major figures (i.e., John Scopes, William Jennings Bryan, and Clarence Darrow), two sides of the controversy (i.e., fundamentalism and modernism), the outcome, and the legacy.

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

The sources

Document A

Tennessee Butler Act, Chapter 27, House Bill 185, enacted March 21, 1925 (Tennessee Acts, 64th General Assembly, public domain)

“An Act prohibiting the teaching of the Evolution Theory in all the Universities, Normals and all other public schools of Tennessee, which are supported in whole or in part by the public school funds of the State, and to provide penalties for the violations thereof. Be it enacted by the General Assembly of the State of Tennessee, That it shall be unlawful for any teacher in any of the Universities, Normals and all other public schools of the State which are supported in whole or in part by the public school funds of the State, to teach any theory that denies the story of the Divine Creation of man as taught in the Bible, and to teach instead that man has descended or ascended from a lower order of animals.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT A

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

Document B

Scopes Trial transcript, cross-examination of William Jennings Bryan by Clarence Darrow, Rhea County Circuit Court, Dayton, Tennessee, July 20, 1925 (public domain, Library of Congress)

“DARROW: Do you think the earth was made in six days? BRYAN: Not six days of twenty-four hours. DARROW: Doesn't it say so? BRYAN: No, sir...I do not think about things I don't think about. DARROW: Do you think about things you do think about? BRYAN: Well, sometimes. [Laughter from the crowd.]”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT B

H — Historical context

What was happening when this was made?

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What was it trying to make the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how does that shape it?

Document C

H.L. Mencken, "Homo Neanderthalensis," Baltimore Sun, July 29, 1925 (pre-1928 publication, public domain)

“Such is the great capital of the Fundamentalists, such is the Athens of the Coca-Cola belt. What could be more lovely?...The yokels have been galvanized. They leap and cavort. They roll and cry. They are led by a prophet who knows all the answers. Bryan is their Moses and their Woodrow Wilson.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT C

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

The question

Using ALL THREE documents and your knowledge of the Scopes Trial (US.31), cultural changes of the 1920s (US.33), and mass media (US.34), write a multi-paragraph response that applies HIPP to each document and constructs an argument about what the Scopes Trial revealed about 1920s American culture. Be sure to identify each document's purpose and point of view, explain what the three together show that no single document shows alone, and use outside knowledge to support your argument. Note: This trial took place in Dayton, Tennessee — identify what the Tennessee context adds to your analysis.

Plan your answer

Your claim	
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Source	Evidence you will use	Why it supports your claim
Document A		
Document B		
Document C		
Outside knowledge		

Write your response

